

STRUCTURE - PHRASES

TYPES OF PHRASES

A phrase is a group of words that do not contain a finite verb. A phrase cannot stand on its own to make meaning. It only forms part of a sentence.

Types of phrases

1. Noun phrase: This is the phrase that does the work of a noun or pronoun in a sentence.
Example:
 - a. John the driver is dead.
 - b. The big ugly girl is quarrelsome.
2. Adjectival phrase: This is the phrase that describes a noun or a pronoun in a sentence. Examples:
 - a. The coat made of cotton is very lovely.
 - b. The girl with dirty hands ate the food.
3. Adverbial phrase: this is the phrase that modifies a verb in a sentence. It answers the question “why, where, when, how? etc. Examples:
 - a. The head boy lives near the church.
 - b. The old man walked slowly across the road.
4. Prepositional phrase: This is a phrase that begins with a preposition. Examples
 - a. Sani was beaten with a cane.
 - b. The woman drowned in the river.

Identification of phrases

1. If the verbs in the expression given is preceded by ‘to’ that verb is non-finite, therefore the expression is a phrase. Example
 - a. He is always ready to fight anybody.
 - b. To pass examination involves hard work.
2. If the verb in the expression functions as an adjective, it is a non-finite verb and therefore the expression becomes a phrase. Example
 - a. I have boiled yam in my pot.
 - b. He has replaced the broken bottle.
3. If the verb in the expression is in the ‘-ing’ form, the verb is non-finite and the expression becomes a phrase. Example
 - a. I saw the boy going to the library.
 - b. Eating supper late is what I don’t like.
4. If the expression underlined in the sentence cannot make meaning when standing alone.
Example
 - a. She is sleeping in the room.
 - b. They are standing outside the gate.

Assignment

Write out ten sentences to show the types of phrases you have been taught, underline such phrases.